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Dave Rivello

Dave Rivello directs the New Jazz Ensemble at the Eastman School of Music, and is an Assistant Professor of Jazz Studies and Contemporary Media. He is a prolific composer of jazz ensemble music and has received commissions from the Smithsonian Institute, the Penfield Music Commission Project, and artists such as Phil Woods and Randy Brecker. The Dave Rivello Ensemble is a 12-piece band that performs his original compositions.

Dave was interviewed in Rochester, NY on January 11, 2012, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Alanna Rowe was present and participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm in Rochester, New York talking to Dave Rivello, band leader, composer, arranger. Does that just about cover it?

DR: Conductor and educator I guess.

MR: Okay. Well thanks for taking some time today. And as the camera is kind of catching, you can see sketches all over the room. And I'm really glad to see real paper, to be honest with you, in this day and age.

DR: Yeah, it's part of the process for me and so the computer has its things and in many ways it's made life easier as a composer and arranger, but for me, I still am — I have to work on paper. And so I write all my scores longhand, I do all my sketching and my full scores longhand, and then put it into the computer to make parts for the musicians. And I'm still in the quest of the best pencils that I can find and the paper you see, the King brand, this is all King brand manuscript paper. And it was used by Bob Brookmeyer, my hero, and Gil Evans, and Al Cohn, and everybody on the east coast at least, all use King brand paper. And so I had a connection with the company that was still making King brand paper and because of technology and computers they're no longer producing it. So basically I bought up everything that I could possibly get and I have a stash all over my house.

MR: Is that right?

DR: Don't come rob me. So I hopefully have a lifetime supply of this particular yellow, custom-milled King brand paper.

MR: I had not heard about that. I mean I used to do the paper scores too. But I didn't know King was the —

DR: King was the king sort of.

MR: King was the king. What does the putting of pencil on paper do for you that the computer doesn't?

DR: A couple of things, and Stravinsky said it much better than I could but, the tactile sense of the hand and touching the paper and so the mind's ear is connected with the arm and the pencil and making the motion. And in the computer there is the mouse, but you're not really making a mark on the paper. And so for me that's a commitment to that note or that voicing or it is saying that I believe in this. And there's a certain strength in that that if I'm gambling and I'm combining notes that you wouldn't think should go together but I believe in those and I make that mark on the paper, there's a thing about that. And that is not — it doesn't happen the same way on the computer.

MR: Now you obviously would have been writing in the days before you could hear it back. And there's something about that moment, you know, when you're in front of the band and you've just written this thing, and you think it's going to work, but hearing it for that first time is like nothing else, right?

DR: It is like nothing else in the world. That's exactly right. And I don't really, even though the technology exists I don't really depend on the computer to play back for me, I still trust my own sense and I still get that feeling. So I might use the computer to play back to check something, but as far as putting in the entire piece and hearing it play back and, "Oh I did good, yay" and then take it to the band, no, it's still that experience for me, that bringing it to the band and hearing it for the first time live with them playing the notes that I put on the paper and it's still that experience, and nothing touches that in the entire world is that experience — the first hearing of something that you created.

MR: I like your set-up. It's almost like you're a draftsman here. And do you often spin around?

DR: All the time.

MR: All the time?

DR: All the time. This is a new set-up. I just got this Steinway, a 1921 piano, from the Eastman School of Music actually. And I only talk about it because it's thrilling to me that this was in the first batch of Steinways that was delivered to Eastman when the doors opened in 1921, and I've always wanted a Steinway upright, and now I have one.

MR: All right.

DR: So the room used to be different, with a giant drafting desk actually, but it doesn't fit anymore so I had to kind of shrink that in order to have it this way. But it seems to be working pretty well.

MR: Can you — I don't know if it's hard to answer this but — how much of what you write can you hear in your head?

DR: I've been writing music since I was in junior high school, not that anybody should ever hear those attempts at that point, but it's been a lot of years. So it's a two part answer I guess. I can hear a lot of things in my head. And if I were to write something very

straightforward then I can hear all of that in my head as I'm creating it. But for me, I'm interested in stretching what I know and what I can do. And so I'm gambling more than I'm not gambling, especially if I'm writing for my own ensemble. So I can still hear that but I don't always know if it's going to work. But I spent fifteen years with the legendary Bob Brookmeyer, and he didn't always know. And I'm good friends with Maria Schneider, and she doesn't always know. And these are people that have been writing music for, Bob especially, for longer than I have been. Bill Holman too, we're friends also. And he sometimes is like, "I'm not sure if it's going to work or not." So part of that never goes away, which is a good thing I think because it means you're trying to expand yourself instead of, you know, if you're just writing straightforward things and banging them out, you should be able to hear those and know that, okay, I can mail it off and forget about it, but I'm not one of those guys.

MR: Something must have inspired you when you were in junior high school — some chart or some writer? Can you recall?

DR: Yeah I remember it like it was yesterday. Actually it was my grandfather, who had a big band on the road in the 1940s. And he lived to be 92, just recently, and he was probably the most amazing man I'll ever know in my life. At 90 years old he wrote his autobiography, and then he was teaching it to people in their 60s and 70s. His book is called *How to Have a Great Life at Any Age*. And I remember distinctly his birthday was on July 4th and it was a backyard party at my parent's house for his birthday. And I asked him something about a particular song that I had heard. And he took a paper plate and he flipped it upside down and he drew five lines for the staff and a treble clef and he wrote out the first few measures just out of his head. And I think, trying to look back, that must have been the moment when I realized wow, I want to be able to do that someday. And so I think that's where — he had a big band on the road in the 40s. He was an accordion player. And he took me, from when I was old enough to walk, every year at a place in Ohio where I grew up there was a place called Idora Park Ballroom. And the sides came down in the summer, off the ballroom, and so every year Maynard Ferguson's band and Buddy Rich's band always came through, and then I also heard Stan Kenton's orchestra there once, and the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis big band there. And later I got to hear Count Basie's band with Count Basie, somewhere else, so that all kind of was part of who I am now I guess.

MR: When you write a chart, to me I always run into this bit about okay, I've done an intro, done the melody, whether or not it has a bridge, and then you get to that point, what am I going to do now? And I think Maria Schneider, she said this to me and I think it came from Bob Brookmeyer. He said, "Wait as long as you can before giving in to a soloist."

DR: Yeah.

MR: Does that sound like something he would say?

DR: That's a Brookmeyer thing for sure. Yeah. When nothing else can happen, that's when the first solo should happen. So you should do everything you can until then. Yeah, that's from Brookmeyer for sure.

MR: So what are those things that you should be trying to do before you go there?

DR: What I think about is continuing to develop whatever material is going on before I turn it over to a soloist. And so whether that's a melodic idea or if then oh well I did this so it was kind of a straightforward thing so maybe I'll do some kind of a counterpoint that's an inversion or a retrograde inversion of what the main material was. You know I just play around with — until it feels right to release my thing to a soloist. And what I've begun doing in the last few years, which also comes from Brookmeyer, is I also then when I finally do have a solo, I give them guidelines of where I at least want them to start. So whether that's pitches or rhythmic ideas or I write a melody and then say continue similarly from here, so that they stay in my piece. Because the problem that Bob has addressed in print and lectures and everything is that you turn it over to the soloist and they play what they've been working on in the practice room and it has nothing to do with what happened up to that point. So I try to guide that a little bit and I also try, with my own band at least, where I have control over the members of the band, to make sure that they understand that you're part of my piece. You know Brookmeyer said it best when he said "a solo is a compositional continuance." Those are his words, not mine. But I'll take them, and I use them.

MR: Yeah. You put them in caps.

DR: Yeah.

MR: That's a nice phrase.

DR: So making sure that they understand and stay in your piece. So that's what I try to do. And there's also, by the way that you create or construct backgrounds behind that soloist also is a way of making sure they stay in your piece. If you just give them open solo and it just goes on forever, they're going to play what they played in the practice room. But if once in a while I'm giving them something motifically or whatever from the piece, they're going to have to deal with that and stay in the piece.

MR: Do they chafe at that?

DR: They might when I haven't heard, but so far nobody's complained.

MR: Have you had to try different sidemen to find the people you like?

DR: I've been fortunate that I do that work on the front end so that I'm very careful about who I ask, especially to be a permanent member of my band. And so generally there'll be subs that I call, good players, and I kind of feel them out and watch their interaction when they're subbing with the band, with the rest of the band. Because for me — the musical

ability obviously is the most important thing. But a very close second is how they act. Because one bad apple, especially my band is a twelve-piece band. One guy who doesn't interact well with the others really changes the picture in a negative way. So I'm very careful about, even somebody who has subbed, if there's an open chair permanently, who is going to come into the band and be that permanent player, I think long and hard about that every time before I make that final decision. So fortunately because of doing it that way I haven't really had any issues with that.

MR: Are you talking about interacting musically and otherwise?

DR: Musically and socially, their attitude, their demeanor, all of those things. You know one guy who thinks that he's better than somebody else is going to really change the picture, and then all of a sudden my regular guys are like, "Oh by the way Dave, yeah, I can't make Thursday's gig" — because it's not fun anymore for them, so the thing that can happen is it starts falling apart. So as long as they know for me as a leader, because anybody with a big band I think — I forget who it was, somebody famous said "Whenever you see a big band playing somebody's losing money." So these guys are not playing for big money. They're doing it because they love to do it and they're having fun doing it. So if one element makes it unfun for them, not fun, then all of a sudden there's a whole other world that opens up that I have to take care of. So by trying to take care of that on the front end and being careful about who I select and who I ask, then I've not had really trouble in that way.

MR: If you could have a seventeen piece big band, would you? Or do you like the twelve?

DR: No actually I like the twelve. To me it's the perfect number. And the reason that I came up with that sized band, in 1993, was I had written a lot of music for standard jazz ensembles. And I realized that by then, and having gone through Eastman and everything with my degree, that I could do four note trombone voicings in my sleep. And so I thought wow I'm kind of stuck here. So what can I do? Well if I take some instruments away, then I have to figure out how to do this. And so I've created my own good problem to move myself forward. Also I've been, besides Brookmeyer, very influenced, and I mean Gil Evans is just a master at everything. So I kind of looked at Gil Evans' bands and they were never full-sized bands. And so I thought wow, so what would be my dream ensemble? And so I decided that I like alto saxophone, but I really like soprano saxophone. So my band has no alto.

MR: No kidding.

DR: Soprano, and he doubles on flute. And then tenor sax of course, and he doubles on flute and clarinet. And I like baritone saxophone but I really like bass clarinet. So there's no baritone saxophone in my band, it's bass clarinet and he doubles on flute and clarinet. And then, because of Gil Evans' influence probably, I wanted to have a tuba. So two

trombones and a tuba. And then I thought about having French horn, also from Gil's influence, but I thought if I've got one non-jazz guy, a tuba player, and I'm in Rochester, New York, two is probably going to be too much of a gamble. So I decided I have two trumpet players and I have the third guy only plays flugelhorn. So I think of that as kind of a French horn that blows forward instead of backwards. And that was I don't have to deal with the acoustical issues of that also. And then piano, bass and drums, the standard jazz rhythm section. And so that's my dream ensemble. And no matter what situation there would be, if I could I would just write for my own band all the time.

MR: You've already got a built-in start on your own sound too with that instrumentation.

DR: Right. And what I knew when I did it too, thinking ahead, is that it would be problematic in that college bands that are seventeen or sixteen piece bands, that it doesn't work so well for them because what are they going to do with the other people, they'll be running around the halls throwing erasers and causing trouble. But for me, that's my dream band to write for. My goal was to just continue writing for that band as I can in and around freelance work, and just create a book, a body of work that is my work for that ensemble.

MR: I was watching a YouTube selection, "Beyond the Fall." I wondered if there's parts in the piece that don't necessarily have chord symbols that can be assigned to these four measures or whatever. Are you beyond thinking that way?

DR: Sometimes. In that piece probably there's moments where the soprano saxophone solo is and those backgrounds are happening and they get more and more dissonant, that it's just, I think I just labeled it as like whatever area I was in harmonically, like D5. So it was just fifths in the bottom and then I let them try to navigate what all the stuff that's happening around them once the backgrounds start coming in. Other than that there's just a lot of sus chords I guess, that could be labelable but in general with my own band the rhythm section parts, there's often not a lot of chord symbols. The bass parts are written out. Jeff Campbell once said that playing bass in my band was like playing fourth trombone. Because everything is written. There's not just where they — maybe in a section where there's soloing there might be in some of the pieces, but other pieces the bass vamp is specifically written. I let the guys — they'll vary from that and come back to it. And then the piano part is eight or ten fingers of generally doubling what's going on in the ensemble, so they're not just sitting there comping. So generally there's not too much chord symbol stuff in many of my pieces.

MR: Wow. I like the idea of using the piano to double parts too. It definitely gives you a different tone. Not that many people employ it that way.

DR: No it's true. And with twelve pieces I've also then got support under there if I need that. I can use the piano to also help if it's a large voicing that will help support underneath or I can have them support the trumpets or wherever it is. But I noticed that, well Brookmeyer

often had, always in his own band, had a pianist and a synthesizer. And one or the other of them, or both, were doubling different parts of the ensemble. And he got a certain sound by doing that. And Maria Schneider also often times she'll double the upper voices of, if they're woodwinds or the trumpets, she'll have that covered in the piano. So her parts are a lot more notated than say Thad Jones, where it was just the harmonic information, just the chords and the pianist is left on their own kind of to figure out where to play, where not to play, and so it's a different way of approaching the rhythm section, but I think about it that as a composer I have a lot of — rights sounds like a strong word but I have the right to control the rhythm section and choose what I want them to do, rather than just kind of letting that be their choice. Sometimes I want it to be their choice, because I want to know what they're going to do there, because that inspires me. But sometimes I want to be sure of exactly what's going to happen and that's when I notate what I want to be there.

MR: Let's talk about writing for school bands. What's the key to writing for, like a middle school band, for you?

DR: The key for me, and this is what I've tried to do with the Alfred pieces that I've written and I write a lot for the Penfield School system too here, and I don't actually honestly know what it is that Jim Doser, I don't know if you know, but Jim is great. Penfield High School and runs the Penfield Music Commission Project, and every year I write for them. And I don't know exactly what it is that he hears, but somehow he says I have an ability to really do that for younger players in a way that a lot of other arrangers can't do. I don't know what that thing is, honestly. But I just think about, I want something that the students will enjoy playing, but I want there to be a weight about it that it's not just the usual, I call it slag for lack of a better term, that's out there that these guys that, they can knock out a couple of these in an afternoon. And for me if I write a Grade Three arrangement of something, I spend as much time on that as I do creating a composition for my own band. And so when I started writing as a staff arranger for Alfred, I mean I take it very seriously because I want that music to have integrity, I want it to be playable by those students so that it's not over their ability, because that's frustrating. But I want it to be a little bit beyond what they might — so that they have to reach for something. So my goal, whether it's successful or not in those pieces, was to just raise the bar just a little bit so that there was music out there that I would want to play if I was a student and I was that age, and really feel like wow, this challenges me but there's something here that I can feel good about being part of. So I don't know if that answers the question.

MR: Sure. I mean you obviously have to know about ranges and what that age level —

DR: Right. It's very specific. You know, Grade Three the second trumpet player, besides the first trumpet player, the second trumpet player can't go higher than this, and the

trombone can't go, and they can't do this, and this can't do that. And so yeah, there's a lot of rules, and mostly I wrote Grade Three. Grade Two of course there's even more rules of what you can't do. And Grade One the ranges get smaller and smaller. So Grade Three is what I mostly do for Alfred so far.

MR: Well my daughter, who has played your music, said she likes the tension and release in it.

DR: That's nice to hear. I like that.

MR: Is there obvious ways you do tension and release?

DR: I don't know if there's obvious ways. I guess still in a world where it can be sometimes bad to follow your ear, because everything is theoretical and everybody wants to talk about, "Oh did you see that this is this and you took this from here" and we seem to live in a time where there's plenty of people who want to look at the nuts and bolts of things and kind of lose the overall musical — what does it do to you and what do you feel from this. But I still use my ear. And I guess the only answer I know is that my ear tells me where the tension and release should happen after spending all of these years kind of absorbing the history of this music and hopefully moving it in some way forward.

MR: That's a good answer. In fact, you lead me to a question about analyzing things to death. This one article I read recently that I'm sort of obsessing about. It's a five plus page article in the latest *JazzEd* magazine about playing, if you had Dm7 to Bflat7, and the possibilities. And this article goes on and on and on for five pages, and there's a matrix and a whole schematic. And for a guy like me, who basically didn't get a jazz education so to speak, I found that I could hardly read it. I mean do you have an opinion on going too far with — or maybe you think that's the way to go. But I'm interested in how you think about that.

DR: The way I think about that is when you are a young musician it's important because jazz was handed down. It was an aural tradition. So I think that when you're younger it's very important to transcribe the masters, and as much as possible get those notes off of the recording without using the technology we have today where there's some things you can just play it in and it actually writes it out for you. No. You take it note for note. You know we used to, there was the Marantz tape decks that would run at half speed so it would slow down and it would be the same pitch an octave lower. And it sounded really crazy, but for 16th or 32nd note things in Coltrane or something you had a chance at getting those notes, and writing it down and then learning that and then playing that with the recording and the inflections, and that's all part of, I think, growing up. I teach it as all music, but jazz because that's specifically what I generally do, as a language. So when we learn how to speak English in our case, first you hear it. So you need to be immersed in it. And then you begin to speak it but it doesn't make sense. That's why as adults we all laugh at the great things that kids say because the words some out in the wrong order.

That's the next thing that's going to happen is somebody learning to improvise. Stuff's going to come out in the wrong order. But over time and as you continue to listen and you continue to assimilate, eventually the sentences start to come out in the right order. But it's necessary to listen and to transcribe and to do that work yourself. It's not the same — you know even when I was a kid there weren't ten thousand jazz books. There were a few things. Jamey Abersold only had — I told a student at Eastman the other day — Jamey Abersold, there was five volumes. They laughed at me like they couldn't believe. I don't know, there's like a hundred and something now. But there were only five of them then. And that was the new thing. And now you can buy a book of, okay, I go out and buy the book of Clifford Brown solos and I sit there with the trumpet and I just play the Clifford Brown solos. Okay I got that. You don't have that. You have that when you listen to Clifford Brown playing that and you struggle for every one of those notes, and you listen back — now it's easier with a CD player — you had to move the needle back like every time, like you couldn't get that and you're scratching the record but you're trying to get that. But you fought for it. And when you fought for it, that was yours then. And that's missing completely I believe, from most of our society today.

MR: That takes a lot of commitment from a student who can go the easy route.

DR: Yeah, it's true. But if it's that important it's that important. And I know I've kind of lost where your question was but I'll get back there if I remember. But for me too I tell people that I could play an example I guess. Let's see if I could make one up. I could spend hours trying to decide, is it this [piano chord] or is it this [piano chord]. Is it this [piano chord] I'll play it a little better, or this [piano chord]. Oh I'm sure it's this one [piano chord]. Well wait a minute, no, I think it's this one now. And then I can do that for hours, trying to decide which of these sounds, that specific. And then I'll go to bed and I'll wake up the next day thinking I know it, it's this one [piano chord] and then [piano chord] no I think it's that one. Hours, just trying to decide between something so simple it's going to by in such a moment of time that nobody listening is ever going to know. It could be either one. But for me, it makes a difference which one it is. So the commitment, if you're committed to making music and you're committed to the art of jazz then that commitment and that commitment to scratching the record and getting those exact notes from Clifford Brown, or whoever, off the record, that's what you need to do. Now you can, if you would, remind me of the original question.

MR: Well maybe you answered my question but I think it's partly that a person with that commitment may be the one that rises to the top. I mean there's so many people out there now trying to get to the same spot, that it requires that kind of thing. I guess my question is, there's so many names, there's all the modes and there's symmetric diminished and

there's all these scales. And if I look at a Dm7 chord, I think of it as a major scale with a lowered third and a lowered seventh. I don't think Dorian. Why should I think Dorian?

DR: I don't think you need to. I think if thinking a lowered third and a lowered seventh works for you, and this is the way I teach, then that's the way you should think of it. Somebody else may think oh it makes it so much easier for me to think Dorian, then that's the way they should think about it and not as a major scale with a lowered third and a lowered seventh. But that's where we were. And so the amount of information that is out there now is overwhelming. I even teach in my jazz pedagogy class at Eastman, I tell them part of your job, especially as a private teacher, is to help your students sift through what they need to know right now. Because they're going to come in with the suitcase full of all this stuff they want to know right now. And that's great — the excitement is great. Okay. Let's learn how to just play quarter notes in time first. We'll worry about the Clifford Brown transcription book later. But and so figuring out — when I had finished my master's at Eastman and I studied with Rayburn Wright and it was fantastic, and I had my first lesson with Brookmeyer. And he said, "Wow, all of this is good. Here's what we're going to do. The first exercise — he calls it the 'white note exercise.' You use from middle C to the C above that. No chromatic notes, that's all you've got. And in the left hand, harmony is just Csus." Write pages and pages of music with that, which in the beginning it sounds like it shouldn't be too hard. Then it sounds like wow, that's kind of dumb. And then all of a sudden it's like this is really hard. And then, if you stay with it you find that, and I teach this now to all my students, you find that you've pushed through certain walls and you can create a lot of interesting music with only the white notes in one octave, and no harmony, I mean except Csus, but you can't rely on that. So he took — I had finished at Eastman School of Music, and he took me down to, "Okay we're going to write the white note exercise." And then there was a harmonic exercise, rhythmic exercises, and kind of re-built the way that I thought about the elements. And in our society there's an incredible lecture and I still use on just the intervals, and the way he goes through, or just playing the power of one note is a better way of saying it. But you know we forget about how strong one note can be. I mean if I just play a C on the piano and just let it ring for a minute, and focus on that note, how long it lasts. And if I wrote that and then I gave you anything else, you're waiting for that. You know and so all of the elements of drama too and just there's so many things, that the amount of material is overwhelming I tell everybody. So I feel that, and it was interesting, and I kind of have that too, I love books, and I like information. Oh I should know about this and I should know about that. And I talked to Brookmeyer once about that and he said, "Well," he said his view was, "write music. Forget about the books. Learn by doing it." And Rayburn Wright said an amazing thing once that changed my life. He said, "well" —

at least for me, maybe everybody else knows this I don't know — but he said, "Books are just a summation of somebody else's experience. Have your own experience." And so my job is to do my work. And however I think about it, it doesn't have to line up with anybody else's way of thinking about it, it's just that I have to go to work every day and if I reinvent the wheel that's okay because it's my wheel and I own that wheel now. So that's the way I look at it. So hopefully that answers the question.

MR: Nicely said. Was there something different you learned from each of your — like Brookmeyer and Bill Holman, and did you seek these people out for a specific reason?

DR: I guess, without really thinking about it, but I sought out Bill Holman because of, you know at least with Brookmeyer and Holman — Rayburn Wright was such an incredible orchestrator and just knew how to get so many colors. Like I said, I came here only to study with him, to understand that. With Holman, with the early recordings — well not with the early recordings but the recordings when Bill wrote for the Kenton band, where it was very linear, and every once in a while you'd get a chord that was just like, oh finally, and then it would go back to being linear, and so he had a whole different approach from just the thickened line and things we were used to and shout choruses, he would just read these lines and it was very much more counterpoint oriented. And so that's what attracted me that I wanted to know from him. And Brookmeyer just, as I said, in 1980 when he came back to Mel's band and did the first record that he did with Mel's band called Bob Brookmeyer Composer/Arranger, and that was after ten years of Bob not writing and being in California and lots of things. And there was a student at Youngstown State and I was there then, and he said, "You have to go to Record Oasis" or whatever it was called in the little mall there, "and you have to get this record, Bob Brookmeyer with the Mel Lewis band." And so I went and I bought the record and I came home and I put it on and I put the needle down and I think the first track is "Ding Dong Ding" the first tune. And in like ten seconds it was like wow. Because I knew Thad's music, I knew Gil's music, I mean that's what I had heard, and this was completely different in such a way that it blew my mind and I realized that this, and now I say, and many of us, Maria Schneider and Darcy Argue and people that have all studied with Bob, in that moment on that record Brookmeyer changed the whole face of large ensemble composition, single-handedly. So when I heard that I thought wow, you know, I was just a little kid from Ohio and I thought oh man it would be so amazing if someday I'd get to meet Bob Brookmeyer. Little did I know that I would spend fifteen years with him and be close with him and all those things, and the things you can't imagine. But I wanted everything from Bob, like harmonic and melodic and just this whole sonic world of what he was doing. So I guess there were specific things but I just knew I needed something, I wanted something from these guys besides just to be around them and hear stories and know

what was it like working with so-and-so and how was this guy like, and so I've been very fortunate in my life to have those guys.

MR: And you did some work as a copyist also, for some of these people.

DR: I did a lot of work as a copyist. I think probably it was more than ten thousand hand-copied pages before the computer came in. I was a pen and ink guy. And I copied for Brookmeyer and I copied for Rayburn Wright and Bill Dobbins, Donald Hunsberger with all the wind ensemble stuff, Joseph Schwantner, Bob Belden in New York, I've done some work for Maria Schneider. So yeah, there were a lot of people — Manny Albam — I copied all of his stuff. So for a while I was the first call pen and ink guy.

MR: No kidding. And did you do that — where did you do that?

DR: Here.

MR: Oh. They would send you the —

DR: Yeah. And Brookmeyer, that's how I actually got to know Bob was he was writing a four movement suite for Clark Terry's seventieth birthday. And I called Bob because his recording called "Electricity" had come out and it wasn't available in the states. And Fred Sturm had said, "Oh here's Bob's number, just call him he'll send you one. He's a nice guy." And I didn't know, I thought because Mulligan and Brookmeyer — Gerry Mulligan and Brookmeyer were close, so I thought well Mulligan is known to be difficult and salty and everything else and I figured out Brookmeyer is probably the same way and I was so afraid. Finally I dialed the number and he said, "Bob Brookmeyer" and "uh hi" you know and we started talking, and I said I was trying to find his "Electricity" CD and he said, "Oh I'll send you one." He said, "What else do you do, besides write music?" Well actually he and Manny Albam were doing the BMI Jazz Composers Workshop in New York. And Manny knew my music from here because I was involved in some of the arranger's holidays and all of that stuff. So Manny I guess had been telling Brookmeyer about me and that I was in Rochester. And so Bob said, "Oh Manny Albam has been telling me about you, I'd like to hear some of your music sometime." So I said wow, okay, so it got a little easier on the phone, I wasn't quite as afraid. And he said, "What else do you do besides a composer." And I said, "Well I'm a copyist." And the computer was kind of happening then. And he said, "Oh are you a hand-copyist or a computer copyist?" And I said, "Well I do both but I prefer to copy by hand." And he just said, "Okay, I might need you sometime." And we hung up and I thought oh Brookmeyer's so forward thinking he probably wants it all computerized, I probably blew that one. And then two weeks later he said, "Okay I need you." He called, "This is Brookmeyer I need you. I've got the seventieth birthday this week, a four movement suite for Clark Terry, I'm behind." Because Brookmeyer was always behind. His way of saying it was "the muse slept late in his house." So then every day there was more pages coming FedEx and

it was incredible because I mean the hand copied parts was a stack of music like this. And I hired two guys. And one or the other was always here, 'round the clock, as I was copying, in the dining room, proofreading every page. Because the deadline was so close. Every time I finished a page I'd give it to them and they'd check it, and then finally —

MR: Proofing it against his —

DR: Score. The score. So he was sending me the hand-written score and then —

MR: Was it a transposed score?

DR: Yes. Transposed. But every day the FedEx guy knocked on the door and there was more pages and we just kept going and going and it was crazy. And so during that time I said to Bob I would call him once in a while and say, "Oh I can't tell, is this a D or an E or whatever it might be" because he was writing fast. I said, "I'd really like to have a lesson with you sometime." And he said, "Oh okay" he said, "well you could come here and you could decide if you want to work with me and I'll decide if I want to work with you." And I figured well half of this equation was figured but if he says no, what am I going to do? Fortunately that didn't happen. So that's how the first lesson happened. And then it went on from there. And I stayed in contact with him pretty much up to the end, two weeks never passed without me calling him to see how he was doing, what he was working on and I kind of tried to stay in touch with him in that way. And it was just magical, and he was so giving and loving, and it was fantastic.

MR: Wow. He hasn't got the recognition of some guys.

DR: No, I think partly because of the ten year absence in the middle there where he was recovering and going to rehab and everything. And he came back, but then the last fifteen years or so he's lived in New Hampshire in a tiny little beautiful wooded place. But I think because he was kind of off the scene, he wasn't in New York, he wasn't in Europe, a lot of people kind of just forgot about him. But, you know, right before he died his newest record came out, with a singer and his band, in Germany, and it's just absolutely fantastic. So all the way up to the end he was still doing great work. And so it's a pretty magical thing.

MR: Yeah, it's something to be really thankful for, that you got to be with these people.

DR: Oh yeah. As I said I pinch myself not only with my own band but all these things that I've been able to have in my life, I pinch myself every day. I'm the luckiest guy in the world.

MR: Okay, so some band director calls you up and says, "I've got some money to spend and I would like you to do an arrangement on 'Tie a Yellow Ribbon 'Round the Old Oak Tree.'" What do you say to that person?

DR: I say, "Let me give you the number of a —"

MR: You know my general question is, what do you turn down or when do you try to suggest something.

DR: It depends on a lot of factors actually. It depends on if I'm interested in the project. Like even a tune like that I might think that might be interesting to see what would happen with that. And then it would also depend on how much leeway do I have. If you want it to sound like the record then the trumpets are going to play [scats] — I'm not the guy for that. But if it can be sort of — so the first thing is I ask questions. What exactly kind of thing are you looking for on "Tie a Yellow Ribbon"? And then what other pieces has your band played? And if there are things that I know, okay so I've kind of got an idea of the level of the band, and if I'm not sure, generally also I'll say well can you send me a recording of some of the things like from a previous concert of the current bands that you have. And then I ask questions about how strong is your trumpet section, what's a comfortable lead trumpet note, and all these things. And then I kind of get the idea of what they can do and what — if they're just looking for something really straightforward I've done that before and so I might be likely to recommend a student who is kind of coming up and needs a little — that they could use the experience. I might say I have a guy that I think would be really better for you for this thing. And it also depends on how busy I am and how much I've got lined up that I'm into the future. Sometimes it's nothing, and sometimes it's a lot.

MR: Sometimes you're like Bob Brookmeyer, way behind?

DR: Sometimes. In fact there was great moment with Brookmeyer that I said, "Bob, I don't know, I'm trying to get this thing done and it's supposed to be done by this date and I'm really behind." And he said, "You can thank me 'cause that came with the lessons." So yeah, so it just depends on the whole situation. It's a difficult question to answer kind of in the abstract. But if I'm not going to do it I make sure that I give them somebody that I trust that will do what it is they're looking to do.

MR: Do you have a fee structure that you can call up and say well here's what I would like for this kind of work?

DR: Not specifically. The way that I've always kind of done it is most of the time if I get called it's not really blind calls, it's somebody that either I was in school with or maybe played in my band or somebody that I know. And so the way that I've always worked that is I do the best I can to find out what their budget is. And if it's really small and not really possible for me to do that then I'm honest about that, or instead of just naming a number I try to find out from them — and if it's a project I really want to do, I'll still do those for free. Like, you know, we want this thing and you can do whatever you want and it's a monster band or it's a pro band, and I'm really interested in like wow, I've always wanted to do that tune. Okay, so then that doesn't have anything to do with money — I

mean money's nice, but if it's something that's more of a commercial thing then it depends on if I know them then maybe they'll bring me in as a guest artist on top of that, so then maybe they'll buy some of my other pieces, so it kind of together makes a package like okay this works. So that doesn't really answer the question but I've never had a specific like this is what I charge or I hang up on you. No.

MR: Yeah. That's ridiculous.

DR: Like, "You've insulted me."

MR: Can you explain your, is there a reason or rhyme to the music on your piano at the moment?

DR: No. There is, sort of. But they don't all fit together. Each one is in some way some other piece that might someday come into existence. So this is something that just happened one night. It's not really that good yet, but it could be something. And this and the things here I'm now in the process of trying to come up with a piece for Peter Erskine with the Eastman New Jazz Ensemble that'll be premiered in May. And so the process of — the struggling process, that's what this is, and all of this, where there's no piece yet. And this is part of some piece that may exist someday, it's got a lot of stuff on there, and some of this is part of something maybe. And here's some chords that I figured out that I like. And these are some voicings that I stole from Jim McNeely over here that I might use someday. And this here is part of a new piece for my band that's still sitting because I've been busy teaching, but that's in progress. Yeah, and then there's sketches and pieces of things all in here that are waiting someday to become something or not.

MR: Do you ever solve composing problems when you don't expect that you would? Like taking a walk or being away from the piano?

DR: Often. For me I've always been like those guys, and I've often wished that I could do this, but there's guys that — they have four or five pieces going at once, and they come to work in the studio or wherever, each day, and they decide which one they're going to work on. For me — that works for them and they like that because it's a variety. For me it doesn't really work. I'm best when I'm working on one piece at once. Because I'm submersed in that. And it's a 24-hour thing. When I'm sleeping I know that my brain is, and I'll wake up some days and I'll know what that is now — I mean not the problem that I showed earlier — but I'll actually wake up and know what it is. And you know the old joke about, you know, having great ideas in the shower. I've solved plenty of things in the shower. Walks are good. But being away from the piano often has solved a lot of musical compositional problems or decisions, yes.

MR: Do you ever have trouble finding titles?

DR: All the time. And I keep lists of things that seem good. And that helps sometimes, and sometimes it's pretty hysterical when you go back to that list and it's like really? I

thought that was going to be a good title? But there's a book that I have somewhere called *All We Need is a Title*. And it's all about the working titles of famous books. And some of them were just awful, but it's interesting to read just what people thought they were going to call something, and famous books, like *Moby Dick* — I can't remember what the original like working title was but it was not that, and so it would have been a whole different experience.

MR: The Big Whale.

DR: Right, something like that. You know, and so, but, yeah, that's always an issue. I've played dictionary roulette where I just opened and — I can't really use that word — I mean everything to try and find —

MR: Because titles can really spin the listener I think. I mean it's like looking at an abstract painting — it's better to look at it without seeing it, at least for me.

DR: Yeah.

MR: I have to look at it first without seeing what it's called. But if I said, oh, "Beyond the Fall," that must have some deep meaning, like I'm going to try to figure this out. Does any of your music have —

DR: The titles have a meaning but the music itself does not necessarily. It's not — what do you call that —

MR: I'm trying to think of the word.

DR: It's not picturesque — that's not the word, what is it called?

AR: Programmatic?

DR: Yes, thank you. It's not programmatic. So I've never really written a piece like this is about my friend Jim, or whatever, like and his life and his struggles. Like it's never been that. But the titles all have some significance. And once in a while the band gets me at the gig talking about and explaining the title.

MR: What's it like working in academe?

DR: I like it. I'm very committed to it and I take it as a big responsibility for the students' futures. And it's tiring in a way because I am committed to it, and I follow-up with these students that have been my students and find out how they're doing if they're in New York and what's going on, and I try to stay in touch with them so that they know it wasn't just the time that they were here, and then okay on to the next guy. You know I take it very seriously and I enjoy teaching, because the students also inspire me.

MR: You're not a full time — are you full time there?

DR: No I'm — I call it "super part time."

MR: Yes.

DR: But right now, the last few years I've been "sabbatical replacement guy," that's also my invented title for myself. But Clay Jenkins was on sabbatical a couple of years ago so I

covered his classes. And then last fall Bill Dobbins was on sabbatical so I taught all the jazz writing courses and his private students. This year Harold Danko was on sabbatical in the fall so I covered that, and then Dariusz Terefenko is on sabbatical this coming semester so I'm covering his thing. So it's been very busy. But then after this year they've all had sabbaticals so then I'm back to "super part time" thing.

MR: Super part time guy. There's some advantage to that, isn't there?

DR: Yes. And I mean I love leading a band, and so the New Jazz Ensemble is just always a blast, and I program the music that I believe in, and the Undergraduate Jazz Pedagogy class that I teach, just in the fall, is great because I feel like I'm helping them to understand about teaching and being committed to teaching. And then the rest of the time I have my own band and I have my own freelance work, so it's very good.

MR: Because if you were full time all the time, something would have to give probably.

DR: Right. Probably. Yeah. But I don't know, I have good energy, so you never know.

MR: I can tell. Can you name three charts, off the top of your head, that you definitely want your writing students to listen to and analyze?

DR: That's a good question. Let's see. "Hang Gliding" by Maria Schneider would be one, which is one of her masterpieces I think; and probably anything by Gil Evans, I mean you can't go wrong there; and then I have so many favorites of Brookmeyer's so I guess something of Bob's. I could be more specific if I really was prepared to think about it, but I would say those — but "Hang Gliding" by Maria Schneider for sure, and then Gil Evans and Bob Brookmeyer. I think if you really dig into those you'd have quite a bit of fuel to go into your future for a while.

MR: Okay. What about something classic? "Shiny Stockings" or those kind of things. Is that a different — I can't finish the question really but, it's another era.

DR: I think understanding that part of things is important. And I believe that anything that the Count Basie Orchestra did, I think you have to just know that. You have to be able to feel that. You have to have listened to it so much that it's part of you. And my favorite, probably, Count Basie album is "Chairman of the Board." And Thad Jones wrote some of the arrangements and Frank Foster's — I think it's Frank Foster — "Blues in Hoss Flat," and that's one of the best things ever. And lots of people know that because it was in the Jerry Lewis movie, you know, "The Nutty Professor" or "The Absent-Minded Professor," whichever one it was with the black and white. But yeah, I think that even a guy that was as progressive as Bob Brookmeyer was, the biggest thrill in his life that he talked about was he played once with Basie's band. And he said like the thrill in his body was never matched with any drugs, anything ever, the rest of his life. And that was, you know, he grew up in Kansas City, he was like a teenager then. And he lived to eighty, almost eighty-two years old, and nothing matched that feeling. So that was in him no matter if he

wrote very strange modern classical music — what people would term strange — but I mean very avante garde, still somehow Basie was in there. And I think that that feeling and that band has to go with anybody who's serious about this music.

MR: Do you have an opinion on how they achieved that, especially with the Great American Rhythm Section?

DR: I think a lot of it had to do with — those guys just lived together, and they played every night on the road. And I think they knew one another and they trusted one another, and it's something that we can't really have now, because there aren't bands that are playing that much. I mean some of those gigs were supposedly six and eight hours long with the Basie band. They were just playing all night. And in the morning they'd leave the club and then they'd come back in the afternoon again and then play all through the night. And you know there were times off where other bands would play on an opposite stage, but still, they were playing so much, it was their life. And I don't know that we can really get back to that. But I think that's a lot of why it felt so good.

MR: If Eastman — I don't know how many jazz majors graduate from Eastman every year, but if you multiply that times the number of universities in the country now who are doing similar work, what's the prospect for a young talented musician with a degree, in the business?

DR: Not too good, to be honest. And I think about that. Because I think not only in music but even say you have a degree in painting. Where are you going to go? You know, you have a degree in poetry. What are you going to do? You know, Starbucks? Hey. But I do believe that with passion and commitment and energy, those people, the ones that are that dedicated, will rise to someplace where they can do their art and make a living. It's a difficult thing because there isn't too much of a place in our society, and with budget cuts and everything else, there's just — so everybody has to find their own way. I think, that's why I take the pedagogy class so seriously. Because I feel that with community colleges, even if somebody is not a music education major, they're a jazz major, but there might be an improvisation class that they could pick up on Tuesday nights in whatever town they're in, or an adult education improvisation class, or something that they can do that will help supplement the music that they want to create. So finding ways — that's why I'm happy that Eastman has the Arts Leadership Program, and so a lot of that seems to be teaching musicians how to create their own gigs, how to get people to show up to those gigs, and so basically, entrepreneurial skills. Because I think that's what's necessary today. It's not just the same way it was where, okay, so I play good and I'm getting hired by Woody Herman's band, and I'm good for a while, and eventually maybe I get tired of that so I play with somebody else for a while, and then I'll get a job teaching college in the town that I settle in. We don't have any of that. So finding ways, creative ways, I

think it's necessary now for musicians to find creative ways to make a living and still stay true to their art.

MR: Well said. Is there pop music these days that you like?

DR: There's some things that catch my interest, not a huge amount I guess lately. But for a while I listened to the alternative rock station, only in the car, I never listen to it on a radio at home. And I would hear bits and pieces of things that I guess have somehow worked their way into my music, because younger guys or guys that play with my band say oh yeah, I could tell that you listened to that stuff for a period of time. So lately I haven't been, only because I've been busy writing, and generally when I'm writing I don't really listen to anything, even things that I know or jazz things. But my rule in teaching has always been, because I also teach in the Eastman High School Summer Jazz Camp. And students occasionally will say oh did you ever hear DJ something or other thing. And I'm like na, I might have missed that one. But if they're passionate and excited about it my rule has always been I'm willing to listen to anything once. But I reserve the right to not like it, and I reserve the right to never want to hear it again. But what it does is it doesn't put the student off, and say oh, no, that's garbage, or stop listening to that. Okay, well bring it in, we'll listen to it and you tell me what about it excites you or what you like about it, and let's talk about it. So sometimes I would hear newer things that way. But I'm not opposed to it. I'm open to influence anywhere that it can come from. So if it's good music it's good music. Duke Ellington said, "There's only two kinds of music, good music and bad music." So I try to live by that also.

MR: If you could go back in a time machine, any spots in the history of jazz that you wish you could descend into?

DR: I guess with my world I would wish that I could have been there in 1966 I think it was, the Village Vanguard, the first night of the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band. I would wish that at some point I could have, which I never had the chance to do, just been in the room, even if it was the electric band of Gil Evans at Sweet Basil, but just to have experienced what it felt like to be in the room, the same room that Gil Evans was in. And non-jazz, but I wish I could have seen the premier of "The Rite of Spring." Because for me that's still the most incredible piece of music maybe ever written, all music included. "The Rite of Spring" for me, that's the thing.

MR: It is mind boggling.

DR: Yeah, that it came out of Stravinsky, but there's not really a clear connection that I've found of like oh well he took some of this and he moved it that much further. It was like, again, a whole new world. And he wrote it in some little tiny room with no heat in Switzerland or something.

MR: Maybe that's why it sounds like it does.

DR: Could be. He was just wanting to be warm. That's why he was pounding on the piano — those chords that are in the strings.

MR: Do you write for strings?

DR: I do. I just did a big project last summer for John Nugent, strings from the RPO and harp and jazz rhythm section, all in jazz standards. So John played that during the jazz festival and it was my first conducting with the baton experience in Eastman Theater and two thousand people. It's supposed to start running on PBS one of these days. They filmed it to be broadcast. So that, and anytime I get the chance to write for studio orchestra — like I had mentioned Jim Doser, and every year he puts together a studio orchestra, and it's an amazing high school studio orchestra. So every year I get to write for the strings and a studio orchestra for him. So whenever I get the chance to write for strings it's one of my favorite things to do.

MR: Do you have any questions, Alanna? Do you have goals for five, ten years from now?

DR: Well one general one, every day when I wake up is that I want to write a better piece of music than I wrote the last one. So if I can just keep doing that the rest of my life and writing a little bit better of a piece than the one I wrote before, that would be enough. But I also have been working on putting a band, a 12-piece band of mine together in New York City because it's cost prohibitive for me to take my band from here there, but I would like to see what the reaction would be for the music that I've created for my band to be performed there. So my thought is a lot of guys who have played in my band here that were regular members now live in New York City, so it kind of makes sense to put together a band there then I'd just travel with the music, and so that's definitely in progress, so that's one of the things coming up. I'm hoping in May to record the second CD of my band. I've got more than enough music to make the next recording. And I'm working on, I did twenty hours of interview with Bob Brookmeyer on the compositional process, and I asked the questions and he answered, and I recorded all that. And it's typed up and needs to be edited now, but eventually, hopefully in the next year or so again, that that'll be a book available "Bob Brookmeyer in Conversation" is the working title.

MR: That's a worthy, noble project.

DR: I'm excited about it, that the world will be able to know some of the amazing things and the way that he thought about creating music that nobody talks about. Nobody talks about it the same way. And so the world will be able to get that.

MR: Speaking of going to New York with a band, how the heck do you get into the Blue Note with your band?

DR: That I don't know, on an off night and you pay I guess.

MR: You pay?

DR: Well occasionally there are the periods where you have to buy the room and you invite the critics or you invite the audience or you do the ticket sales. So — the Blue Note I don't know. I think you have to be a Chick Corea or somebody — maybe he has to pay. But there's plenty of other places that people are paying attention to. So we'll see what happens with that, but that's definitely on the front burner.

MR: Anything you want to add yourself here?

DR: I don't think so. Your questions have all been great and I'm just thrilled that you asked me to do this.

MR: Well I think we're going to be hearing a lot more from you in the future. So I'm glad to get you at this point.

DR: I hope so. I don't know, just every day I just do my work. That's all I know.

MR: Right. Well best of luck to you.

DR: Thank you.

MR: I enjoyed the conversation.

DR: Same here.

MR: Over and out.